

City of Cambridge, Massachusetts Land Use Data Metadata

All data and information in this dataset are accurate to the best of our knowledge at the time of publication and is subject to revision or retraction at any time.

Update Frequency: Updated annually, after June 30.

Source:

This data set derives from several sources. The primary source is the Assessor's property database. The data set has further been supplemented with development information provided by building permits issued by the Inspectional Services Department, lodging house data from the Cambridge Licensing Board, land use sales and purchases reported by educational institutions via the annual Town Gown reporting process, and from data collected for the Community Development Department's quarterly Development Log publication.

Use codes present in the Assessor's property database combine aspects of land use, tax status, and condominium status. In an effort to clarify land use on particular properties, different codes are used in many cases for this dataset.

Data Collection:

Assessing data is collected by the City Assessor's office. Building permit data is supplied by the Inspectional Services Department. Development Log data is collected by Community Development department staff from project developers, other City staff and various administrative data sources. Sales and acquisitions by educational institutions reported through annual Town Gown process. Data is updated on an annual basis, with a focus on changes in housing unit counts and parcel use.

Limitations of the Data:

The Community Development Department relies on administrative data provided by various entities to construct and update this table. Our staff is unable to verify all reported changes through field checks.

Data Field Definitions:

- **Map-Lot:** This a unique parcel identifier used by the Assessing data system. Map-Lot values are subject to revision as the Assessing department makes ongoing changes to its database. When these changes affect parcels undergoing development these changes are captured as part of the annual update cycle. Changes made outside of the development process might not be recorded here.
- **Street Address:** In the great majority of cases this is the street address of the parcel as it is listed in the Assessor's property database.
- **Place Name:** In some cases, an additional name is provided to help identify the property.
- **Neighborhood:** Refers to the numerical designation assigned to the local area and references a neighborhood name. Cambridge is divided into 13 neighborhoods:

1.	East Cambridge	6.	Mid-Cambridge	11.	North Cambridge
2.	MIT	7.	Riverside	12.	Cambridge Highlands
3.	Wellington-Harrington	8.	Baldwin	13.	Strawberry Hill
4.	The Port	9.	Neighborhood Nine		
5.	Cambridgeport	10.	West Cambridge		

For more information see: <https://www.cambridgema.gov/CDD/planud/neighplan>

- **Land Area:** These figures indicate the physical area of the parcel. In instances where the area reported by the Assessing data system differed from the area reported by the Cambridge GIS system by more than 10% an effort was made to reconcile sources and correct errors.
- **Use Code:** The three- or four-digit code in this field indicates the primary usage of a parcel. While the codes derive from the standard Massachusetts assessing land use classification system, they differ in a number of cases; *the coding system used here is unique to this data set*. Note that other minor uses may occur on a property and, in some cases, tenants may introduce additional uses not reflected here (e.g., office space used as a medical office, home-based businesses).
- **Use Description:** The short description gives more detail about the specific use indicated by the Land Use Code. Most descriptions are taken from the standard Massachusetts assessing land use classification system.
- **Use Category:** This broader grouping of land uses can be used to map land use data.
- **General Use Category:** This is an even broader grouping of uses. You can find a map of land use by general use category here:
<https://data.cambridgema.gov/Planning/Land-Use-Map/hdjy-6cme>
- **Mixed Use:** Two flags are used for this field. “Groundfloor” indicates that a commercial use is found on the ground floor of the primary building, and upper floors are used for residential purposes. “Mixed” indicates that two or more uses are found throughout the structure or multiple structures on the parcel, one of which is residential.
- **Residential Units:** This value indicates the number of existing residential units as of the most recent update. A residential unit may be a house, an apartment, a mobile home, a group of rooms or a single room that is occupied (or, if vacant, intended for occupancy) as separate living quarters. This includes units found in apartment-style graduate student housing residences. Rooms in assisted living facilities that do not provide a high level of medical support and boarding houses rooms are also treated as housing units. The unit count does not include college or graduate student dormitories, nursing home rooms, group homes, or other group quarters living arrangements.
- **Group Quarters:** A value of “True” indicates that the primary use of the property is as a group quarters living arrangement. Group quarters are a place where people live or stay, in a group living

arrangement owned or managed by an entity or organization providing housing and/or services for the residents. Group quarters include such places as college residence halls, residential treatment centers, skilled nursing facilities, group homes, military barracks, correctional facilities, and workers' dormitories.

Most university dormitories are included under the broader higher education land use code, as most dormitories are included in the larger parcels comprising the bulk of higher education campuses.

- **Grad Student Housing:** A value of “True” indicates the parcel is used to house graduate students in apartment style units. Graduate student dormitories are treated as a higher education land use while the living quarters are counted as housing units.
- **Condo:** “True” indicates the presence of residential condominium units on the parcel. Condo properties can include one or more uses, including residential, commercial, and parking, but this field is to track residential condo units. The great majority of such properties in Cambridge are residential only.
- **Tax Status:** A value indicates that the parcel is not subject to local property taxes. The following general rules are employed to assign properties to subcategories, though special situations exist in several cases.
 - **Authority:** Properties owned the Cambridge Redevelopment Authority and Cambridge Housing Authority.
 - **City:** Properties owned by the City of Cambridge or cemetery land owned by the Town of Belmont.
 - **Educ:** Includes properties used for education purposes, ranging from pre-schools to university research facilities. (More detail about the level of education can be found using the Land Use Code.)
 - **Federal:** Properties owned by the federal government, including the Post Office. Certain properties with assessing data indicating Cambridge Redevelopment Authority ownership are in fact owned by the federal government as part of the Volpe Transportation Research Center and are so treated here.
 - **Other:** Nontaxable properties owned by a nonprofit organization and not falling within one of the other categories.
 - **Religious:** Properties owned by religious organizations. Parochial schools located on separate parcels from other uses are included in the Education Nontax category.
 - **State:** Properties owned by the State of Massachusetts, including those owned by the MBTA, Middlesex County, and DCR parklands.
- **Note:** Any notes that are relevant to understanding the land use of the property.

For More Information

For additional information about this data set contact Scott Walker, Senior Manager for Data Services, at 617-349-9462 or swalker@cambridgema.gov. For GIS-related questions contact Brendan Monroe, GIS Analyst, at 617-349-4641 or bmonroe@cambridgema.gov.

Table of Land Use Codes

The following table lists all land use code found in the data layer:

Use Code	Use Description	Use Category	General Use Category
0101	MXD SNGL-FAM-RES	Residential with Ground Floor Commercial	Mixed Use
0104	MXD TWO-FAM-RES	Residential with Ground Floor Commercial	Mixed Use
0105	MXD THREE-FM-RES	Residential with Ground Floor Commercial	Mixed Use
0111	MXD 4-8-UNIT-APT	Residential with Ground Floor Commercial	Mixed Use
0112	MXD >8-UNIT-APT	Residential with Ground Floor Commercial	Mixed Use
0121	MXD BOARDING-HS	Residential with Commercial	Mixed Use
013	MULTIUSE-RES	Residential with Commercial	Mixed Use
031	MULTIUSE-COM	Commercial with Residential	Mixed Use
0340	MXD GEN-OFFICE	Office	Mixed Use
0406	MXD HIGH-TECH	Office/R&D	Commercial
041	MULTIUSE-IND	Commercial with Residential	Mixed Use
0942	Higher Ed and Comm Mixed	Education with Commercial	Mixed Use
101	SNGL-FAM-RES	Residential	Residential
1014	SINGLE FAM W/AU	Residential	Residential
102	CONDOMINIUM	Residential	Residential
1028	CNDO-RES-PKG	Residential	Residential
104	TWO-FAM-RES	Residential	Residential
105	THREE-FM-RES	Residential	Residential
106	RES-LAND-IMP	Transportation	Transportation
1062	RES LND-IMP UND	Vacant	Vacant
1067	RES-COV-PKG	Transportation	Transportation
109	MULTIPLE-RES	Residential	Residential
1091	MULT-RES-1FAM	Residential	Residential
1094	MULT-RES-2FAM	Residential	Residential
1095	MULT-RES-3FAM	Residential	Residential
1098	MULT-RES-4-8-APT	Residential	Residential
111	4-8-UNIT-APT	Residential	Residential
112	>8-UNIT-APT	Residential	Residential
113	ASSISTED-LIV	Boarding House/Assisted Living	Residential
114	AFFORDABLE APT	Residential	Residential
121	BOARDING-HSE	Boarding House/Assisted Living	Residential

130	RES-DEV-LAND	Vacant	Vacant
131	RES-PDV-LAND	Vacant	Vacant
132	RES-UDV-LAND	Vacant	Vacant
1322	RES-UDV-PARK (OS) LN	Vacant	Vacant
1322	RES-DEV-PARK-LAND	Public Open Space	Open Space
140	CHILD-CARE	Education	Education
300	HOTEL	Hotel	Commercial
302	INN-RESORT	Hotel	Commercial
304	NURSING-HOME	Health	Health
316	WAREHOUSE	Commercial	Commercial
323	SH-CNTR/MALL	Commercial	Commercial
324	SUPERMARKET	Commercial	Commercial
325	RETAIL-STORE	Commercial	Commercial
326	EATING-ESTBL	Commercial	Commercial
327	RETAIL-CONDO	Commercial	Commercial
330	AUTO-SALES	Commercial	Commercial
332	AUTO-REPAIR	Commercial	Commercial
334	GAS-STATION	Commercial	Commercial
336	PARKING-GAR	Transportation	Transportation
337	PARKING-LOT	Transportation	Transportation
340	GEN-OFFICE	Office	Commercial
341	BANK	Commercial	Commercial
342	MEDICAL-OFFC	Health	Health
343	OFFICE-CONDO	Office	Commercial
345	RETAIL-OFFIC	Office	Commercial
346	INV-OFFICE	Office	Commercial
353	FRAT-ORGANIZ	Commercial	Commercial
362	THEATRE	Commercial	Commercial
375	TENNIS-CLUB	Commercial	Commercial
390	COM-DEV-LAND	Vacant	Vacant
391	COM-PDV-LAND	Vacant	Vacant
392	COM-UDV-LAND	Vacant	Vacant
3922	CRMCL REC LND	Vacant	Vacant
400	MANUFACTURNG	Industrial	Industrial
401	WAREHOUSE	Industrial	Industrial
404	RES-&-DEV-FC	Office/R&D	Commercial
406	HIGH-TECH	Office/R&D	Commercial
407	CLEAN-MANUF	Industrial	Industrial
413	RESRCH IND CND	Industrial	Industrial
422	ELEC GEN PLANT	Utility	Utility
424	PUB UTIL REG	Utility	Utility
430	TELE-EXCH-STA	Utility	Utility

440	IND-DEV-LAND	Vacant	Vacant
442	IND-UDV-LAND	Vacant	Vacant
9001	Government Operations	Government	Government Operations
910	DCR- State Parks and Rec	Public Open Space	Open Space
9100	DCR- State Parks and Rec	Public Open Space	Open Space
920	Parklands	Public Open Space	Open Space
930	Government Operations	Government	Government Operations
930	Vacant City	Vacant	Vacant
933	Vacant Local Education	Vacant	Vacant
934	Public Schools	Education	Education
936	Vacant, Tax Title	Vacant	Vacant
940	Private Pre & Elem School	Education	Education
9403	Private Elementary Education	Education	Education
941	Private Secondary School	Education	Education
9410	Private Secondary Education	Education	Education
9413	Private Secondary Education	Education	Education
942	Private College	Higher Education	Education
9420	Private College, University	Higher Education	Education
9421	Private College Res Units	Education Residential	Residential
943	Other Educ & Research Org	Higher Education	Education
946	Vacant (Private Ed)	Vacant	Vacant
953	Cemeteries	Cemetery	Cemetery
955	Hospitals, Medical Office	Health	Health
956	Museums	Education	Education
957	Charitable Services	Charitable/Religious	Charitable/Religious
960	Religious	Charitable/Religious	Charitable/Religious
9600	Church	Religious	Charitable/Religious
970	Housing Authority	Residential	Residential
9700	Housing Authority	Residential	Residential
971	Water Utility	Utility	Utility
972	Road Right of Way	Transportation	Transportation
975	MBTA/Railroad	Transportation	Transportation
995	Privately Owned Public Open Space	Public Open Space	Open Space